

same – the camera icon shows up on one of the home screens. The snaps show up in the Photos app, while the recorded videos show up in Videos. With BlackBerry, there isn't a concept of home screens yet, and you need to access the camera app from within the application list. The OS usually has a Media folder, which hosts the separate folders for the pictures and videos you take. Windows Phone 8 lets you pin the camera as a tile on the first screen. This is indeed very convenient, particularly because you can move the tile around depending on how often you use it. As you can see, it is fairly even across all OSes in this aspect. What makes the difference in the end, is the quality of the camera, and how well you actually use it!

Share

Carrying on from our previous point, we now look at how easy it is to share a picture or update your status on multiple social networks from within the phone. We are considering Twitter, Facebook and Instagram for this comparison. All Android phones that we have tested came with the Facebook app preloaded. Twitter has been preloaded on some phones, while it has been conspicuously missing on others. You will need to download Instagram separately as well.

For iOS, Facebook and Twitter are integrated out of the box. Instagram can be downloaded from the App Store. But with Facebook now the master, expect Instagram to be preloaded the iOS devices and most Android phones as well. BlackBerry OS 7 comes with Facebook and Twitter preloaded – only Facebook for OS 6 devices. There is no Instagram app for the BlackBerry platform yet. Neither Facebook nor Twitter are bundled on a Windows Phone device out of the box, and there's no Instagram app for the WP platform. That said, since Microsoft doesn't even load their own Skydrive app on devices, perhaps it's a download only what you want philosophy.

Find it

Some Android phones feature a search button below the display, while some don't. You can always opt for the Search app for the same results. Alternatively, pin a widget on to the home screen.

On Android Jelly Bean, the Google Now service is also available via the Search app. On iOS Swipe left to right on the main screen to open the search screen. However, on iOS, the search feature is fairly limited.

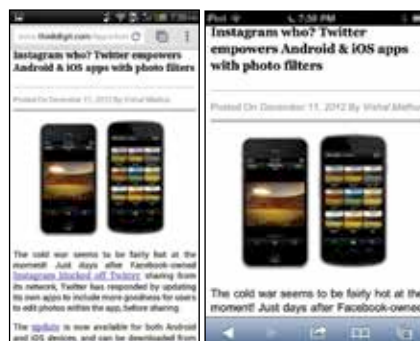


Clockwise from top left: Search on iOS, Android, RIM and Windows

You will probably be better off downloading the Google application. For BB There is the search key on the top right of the screen. Access that by tapping on it (touchscreen devices) or selecting via the trackpad. The results will throw up results from within various data stacks on the device, with the interesting option of "Search Google". With Microsoft keeping a close watch on what manufacturers are doing, the Search key is pretty much mandatory. Bing Search has the most visually appealing UI, but results are just not as good as Google.

Browse

This is pretty much a toss-up between Android and iOS, and we would recommend using the Chrome browser on whichever platform you select, and additionally offer very good experience overall, with lots of sharing options via social networks. BlackBerry's browser is fairly clunky and not worth much bother, honestly. The Internet Explorer on Windows Phone 8 is much better than the predecessor, but same



Chrome on Android and Safari on iOS

web pages take slightly longer to open than on Chrome on Android or iOS.

Typing frenzy

This is open for a lot of debate. But still, nothing beats the combination of BlackBerry's service and the QWERTY keypad for typing out quickly whatever it is that you need to. Gmail and Hotmail have apps for Android, while Gmail is also available for iOS. But, you still cannot sync an Apple iCloud mail address with an Android or a BlackBerry phone! Whatever the fanboys may have to say about this, but a BlackBerry is still the best device for those who need a keypad and primarily use the phone for emails. For those of you who are not very comfortable typing quickly or for long durations on a touchscreen, a QWERTY keypad phone is a must-have for you.

Grooving to the music

They make the iPod! No prizes for guessing that iOS is the best platform for music playback. The critics may say "no drag and drop", but for those who like to consolidate music in one place, update album art and even buy music, iTunes is the best solution. Android is fighting back to a certain extent, particularly with HTC phones offering Beats Audio. RIM's music player on BlackBerry and Microsoft's Windows Phone are clearly also-rans.

Addicted to video

Has to be an Android device. Natively, it can handle quite a few formats, and there are a whole bunch of third party apps that add more. BlackBerry and Windows Phone devices can also handle their fair share of video formats natively. But, in this aspect, iOS takes a major beating, considering the very limited video format support on iTunes and on the devices. It is a pain re-encoding every video just so that it will play back on the iPhone or the iPad.

App-addicted

Your choice is limited to Android and iOS. Between these two, Android has the slight advantage of offering more apps that are free – WhatsApp being a prime example. The application stores on both platforms are bursting to their seams. BlackBerry and Windows Phone have a long way to go before they come close to Android and iOS's sheer numbers and even quality, for the most part. ■